



LIGHTNING TORCH

051 / 19 JAN 2019 / BITCOIN / COMMON

PASS IT ON.

On January 19, 2019, the pseudonymous Bitcoin user Hodlonaut began a small social experiment: send 100,000 satoshis over the Lightning Network and ask the next person to add 10,000 before passing it on. The payment became the Lightning Torch, also called the LN Trust Chain. Its progress depended on each recipient choosing to continue the relay.

Lightning made this practical with payment channels built on Bitcoin. Payments could travel without a separate transaction on the base blockchain for every transfer. The torch gave a technical idea a human shape: receive a payment, find the next participant and pass the growing amount onward.

The proposed increment was a simple shared rule, but the actual history had exceptions. CoinGecko's participant report records two thefts followed by community restarts, as well as a much larger contribution at one hop. The relay relied on social trust between recipients, even though Lightning itself supplied the payment mechanism.

By its April 2019 conclusion, the experiment had crossed a wide community. CoinGecko recorded 291 hops, 281 unique recipients and 56 countries over 83 days, ending on April 11. Its own handoff connected a sender in Argentina with a recipient in New York. Those numbers describe the relay, not the route of any physical object.

HISTROVE imagines a handoff beside a Portofino-inspired harbour. The satchel carries the opening date, starting amount and travel motifs; the lantern bears the requested increment. The two fictional travellers make a digital relay visible. Their boat is a metaphor, not evidence of a real journey.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 THE DATE TAG

The satchel's tag reads 19 JAN 2019, marking the experiment's start. It dates the historical event, not a documented meeting in this harbour.

02 THE STARTING RECEIPT

The slip tucked into the satchel records the initial 100,000-satoshi payment. It is an invented prop representing that amount, not an original receipt.

03 THE TRAVEL SATCHEL

A globe motif, travel stamps and Bitcoin pin suggest the relay's international reach and currency. They do not identify particular stops or a physical route.

04 THE LANTERN INCREMENT

The lantern's +10,000 SATS mark recalls the requested addition before each onward payment. The lantern symbolises the torch; actual contributions were not always uniform.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Sources: CoinGecko Q1 2019 report, pp. 26-29; Lightning Network technical overview. The Portofino-inspired harbour, people, lantern, satchel and boat are fictional metaphorical imagery. The scene does not document a real handoff or boat journey, and the people are not portraits of known participants. PASS IT ON. is an editorial caption, not an attributed historical quotation.